Geographical adventures in residence at the National Gallery of Ireland

Sandra Austin

In this article, Sandra explains how connections with, and residency in, an art gallery can enable pupils to develop agency and confidence in exploring ideas about place.

On a cold February morning a crocodile of school pupils is entering the National Gallery of Ireland. As each pupil crosses the threshold, they take turns to fist-bump the security guard and wave to their new friends at the information desk. They then make their way to a classroom in the Millenium Wing Studio for the start of a new school day: routine, yet extraordinary.

Our primary school in the gallery

In February 2022, two primary classes from a school in Dublin city became the first 'school in residence' at the National Gallery of Ireland (NGI – see web panel). Over the course of two weeks, pupils from 5th and 6th classes (8–10-year-olds) used the whole gallery to explore subjects across the curriculum, including art, English, mathematics, geography, science and history. During the second week of their residency, the pupils conducted tours of the NGI for the other pupils in their school, sharing their learning and demonstrating the confidence and communication skills they had developed. At the end of their residency, the pupils curated an 'Open Studio' display within the NGI, which was viewed by more than 2000 people. All the pupils who participated in the project have severe dyslexia, and the display of their work centered their voices publicly within the gallery.

This project was inspired by 'My Primary School is at the Museum' (MPSM – see web panel), which was conceived by architect Wendy James and developed in collaboration with Kings College London. MPSM's strategy to place classes within museums and galleries for extended periods has clearly demonstrated multiple benefits for pupils, parents, teachers, museums and schools. For pupils, these include increased confidence and communication skills, and their teachers have been empowered to use the curriculum creatively in out-of-school spaces.

Collaborative planning

The structure of the NGI residency was the result of an intense period of collaborative planning by a museum educator, the two classroom teachers and a teacher educator (me). We combined our knowledge and expertise to think beyond the classroom – interpreting and adapting the primary curriculum to fully utilise the wonderful resource of museum/gallery space in pupil learning. Along the way we developed a supportive, mutually-inspiring community of practice. We took an enquiry approach throughout, using the NGI and the art within it as a stimulus to learning and the pupils' interests and questions to drive our explorations. Reflection formed an essential component of each lesson, with pupils encouraged to write diary entries each evening as a bridge between home and gallery.

Throughout the first week, pupils experienced all areas of the curriculum through three sessions of learning each day with their teachers, the gallery staff and me respectively. The sessions took place in the galleries, the Studio and behind the scenes. In between, pupils explored all areas of the NGI and were introduced to, and worked with, various gallery teams: curators, guides, art handlers and artists in residence.

An exploration of urban living

The school is local to the NGI and situated in the heart of Dublin city. At the beginning of the first week, as I was getting to know the pupils and they were still finding their way around the gallery, we explored artworks that focused on cities, streets and neighbourhoods. We took the opportunity to discuss urban living: what does it mean to live in a city? How do people work and live together? Inspired by the adventures of Clarke and Witt (2016), we considered the perspectives of experts in city living: pigeons. We created pigeon companions, took them on a sensory exploration of urban paintings around the gallery and considered questions such as:

- What might it sound/smell/feel like to be in this place?
- How might our own experience here be different from that of our pigeon companion?
- How might our experience in this place compare with our experience in the places we encounter in other paintings?

Moving back into the Studio, we continued by considering what our ideal city might contain. Pupils then spent time using recyclable materials to construct their 'ideal city' (Figure 1). They were free to work together or alone using the huge floorspace available for their expanding cities. These metropolises contained an interesting mix of well-known Dublin landmarks (e.g. the Peppercannister church, Aviva stadium) and imaginative creations (e.g. an entertainment megaplex). Pupils were then given time to explore their peers' cities, to question each other about the elements they had chosen to include (or not) and to reflect on what they valued in their cities.

Looking back/thinking ahead: mapwork and reflection

In preparation for week two we extended our geographical thinking through mapwork. We reflected on our experience of the Gallery so far, with each pupil choosing their favourite pieces of art and deciding on a route through the NGI to highlight these. Next, pupils were encouraged to consider how we might represent this route on a map. I suggested we might draw our favourite artworks, but pupils struggled with the focus required for drawing, so we created collages instead (Figure 2).



Figure 1: Pigeons fly over a newly created city. Photo © Sandra Austin.



Figure 2: The maps used photographs to locate the artworks in the Gallery. Photo © Sandra Austin.



Figure 3: Curating the Open Studio. Photo © Sandra Austin.



Figure 4: Showing others around the Open Studio. Photo © Sandra Austin.

During their gallery explorations, the pupils had taken lots of photos of artworks that intrigued or appealed to them. The choosing, cutting out and arranging prints of the photos on our maps was accompanied by much chatter and laughter.

At this point we also explored the floor plans in the Gallery Guide to anchor our journey maps. The complex layout of the NGI across a number of buildings and floors means that, although I have visited many times, I still get lost. I thought the pupils might struggle to interpret the Gallery's floor plans. Instead, these became central to many pupils' maps. I was impressed the pupils could orient and find their way around, both in real life and on the Gallery floor plans. A selection of pupil maps were displayed during the Open Studio exhibition, and some pupils' pigeons also put in an appearance as Gallery guides and companions.

Taking ownership: displays and tours

At the end of the first week, the pupils collaborated in hanging their Open Studio exhibition in the Millennium Wing Studio. For some pupils, this activity was the highlight of the week: they decided what to hang and its arrangement (Figure 3). For the layout, pupils chose a chronological approach: moving from Monday through to Friday as visitors navigate the space.

Throughout the second week, the pupils welcomed their schoolfriends, class by class, to the Gallery. As well as leading tours of their favourite artworks and activities in the Studio to share learning from their residency, pupils gave presentations and led their peers through the Gallery (Figure 4). Nerves were quickly replaced with pride and confidence, conversation was full of 'insider knowledge', and the residency pupils' sense of ownership shone through as they moved through the Gallery with ease and belonging.

Overall, the project was transformative: it demonstrated the power of in-depth learning, with pupils feeling comfortable and confident in the Gallery. Pupils assumed control of their own learning, making responsible choices, working both collaboratively and independently, sharing newly-discovered knowledge and engaging with new skills.

The class teachers described the richness of the experience for both the pupils and themselves and observed that – as the residency progressed – we achieved more than the original learning objectives. They also commented on how using the NGI increased curricular access and facilitated the use of inclusive learning methods thus catering for different learning styles.

For everyone involved, the experience was positive, enriching and certainly something we would love to do again. Happily, the success has led to 'School in Residence' becoming a regular feature in the NGI's education calendar.

Acknowledgements

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Reference

Witt, S. and Clarke, H. (2016) 'Making connections in the company of pigeons', *Primary Geography*, 91, pp. 12–14.

Web Resources

My Primary School is at the Museum: *https://sites.google.com/brookes.ac.uk/mpsmatbrookes/homepage-welcome-to-my-primary-school-is-at-the-museum?authuser=0&pli=1*

National Gallery of Ireland: *https://www.nationalgallery.ie/explore-and-learn/schools/my-primary-school-museum*

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